

Blu-Ray

Blu-Ray drives were pretty expensive till a few years back and thus this medium hasn't achieved much penetration yet. However, things have begun changing, laptops are increasing shipping with in-built Blu-Ray drives instead of CD / DVD combo drives. They come in a few variants with the highest capacity rated at 128 Gigabytes. With the current trend of increasing display resolutions, providing high quality media requires a proportionally increasing amount of space and the Blu-Ray delivers that. The PS3 used to be favoured purchase if one wanted a Blu-Ray drive as you could not only use the disc drive but could also play games, however, Blu-Ray players have become cheap enough since the last two years so getting one is easier on the pocket now.

Write speeds

When you see an optical drive or a medium then you'll likely notice a set of numbers and x(s) like 52x / 48x / 16x, these simply refer to the speed at which the drive can read / write and rewrite discs. The "x" or the multiplier varies from medium to medium. For CDs the x translates to 150 KB/s. So a 52x drive can read a CD at 52 times 150 KB/s data rate.



There is a simple labelling system used on CDs and DVDs that tells you what all can be accomplished with the particular optical medium. This is done by using the letter(s) R or RW in conjunction with a - or + sign. Here is how they are to be deciphered.

1. R – a plain R written as “CD R” stands for Recordable, i.e. this means the disc is not a pre-burned medium, however, the R notation is preceded by either _ or + sign.
2. -R – this means that the CD or DVD can only be written once and that too must be done in one session. So if you burn a CD-R disk then it is finalised and no further write cycles are possible. There are certain exceptions on the hardware side as certain optical drives will burn multiple sessions onto a -R disc.
3. +R – this means that the disc supports writing once but in multiple sessions. So you can use these as backup discs and add data from time